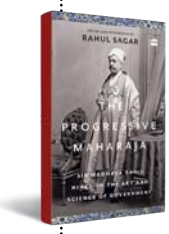
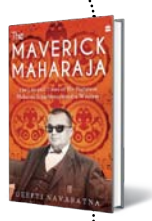
GOD SAVE THE KINGS

New books about monarchs and their majesty



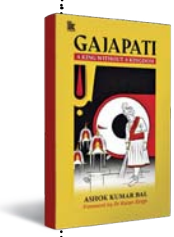
THE PROGRESSIVE MAHARAJA: SIR MADHAVA RAO'S HINTS ON THE ART AND SCIENCE OF GOVERNMENT
by Rahul Sagar (Editor)
HARPERCOLLINS
₹699; 472 pages

The first treatise on statecraft to have been produced in modern India, *Hints on the Art and Science of Government* comprises the lectures that Raja Sir T. Madhava Rao delivered in 1881. This new edition is crucial reading for those who wish to know what good governance looks like.



THE MAVERICK MAHARAJA: THE LIFE AND TIMES OF HIS HIGHNESS MAHARAJA JAYACHAMA-RAJENDRA WADIYAR
by Deepti Navaratna
HARPERCOLLINS
₹599; 316 pages

The last Maharaja of Mysore, Jayachamarajendra Wadiyar, was a philosopher, photographer, conservationist, writer and a patron of Carnatic and western classical music. This book shows how both ethics and aesthetics shaped his predilections.



GAJAPATI: A KING WITHOUT A KINGDOM
by Ashok Kumar Bal
KONARK PUBLISHERS
₹895; 480 pages

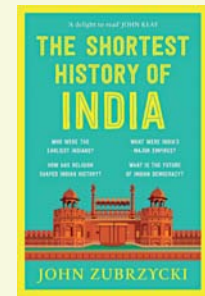
Even when they were at the height of their powers, the Gajapatis told their subjects, the people of Odisha, that they were only servants of Lord Jagannath. Though things went downhill for the royals after the 15th century, this book explains how Gajapati kings flourished by melding temple with state.

BOOKS

Long Story Short

John Zubrzycki recounts India's history in under 300 pages

The periodisation of Indian history remains a matter of scholarly debate, often contentious. It might then be wise to write a popular history of the subcontinent by avoiding the ancient-medieval-modern division, thus side-stepping these debates. John Zubrzycki's 'shortest' account of India's past (and present) covers the several thousand years from the earliest humans to the ongoing pandemic. He has selected representative aspects of key moments that correspond to standard narratives of serious textbooks. There are hardly any relatively recent single-author histories covering such a vast period, perhaps other than the book by John Keay. Zubrzycki has undertaken a rather daunting task in attempting a briefer history of the huge subcontinent, and has been successful.



THE SHORTEST HISTORY OF INDIA
John Zubrzycki
PICADOR INDIA
₹599; 288 pages

There are hardly any relatively recent single-author histories covering such a vast period

The account begins with the discovery of the Harappan civilisation and its dating in the 1920s, which pushed back, by several centuries, the known past of India. Subsequent excavations have revealed that the civilisation had its origins in neolithic villages such as Mehrgarh in Baluchistan (c.7000 BCE), and evolved into its mature phase around 2500 BCE. The end of the civilisation (c. 1900 BCE) overlapped with Aryan migrations. The Vedic-Sanskrit-speaking Aryans initially settled in the north-west. Their spread into the Ganga-Yamuna Doab coincided with the use of iron, which made possible the clearing of dense forests. The emergence of complex societies led to the emergence of states, which in turn facilitated the rise of the Magadhan empire under the Mauryas, reaching its peak under Ashoka. Next, the rulers of the Kushanas contributed to Indian civilisation through their "patronage of Gandharan art and Buddhist architecture". The book adheres to the traditional dynastic format, in which the era of the Guptas (c. 320-550 CE) is regarded as the "classical age". Zubrzycki casts a glance at the Pallavas and Cholas in the south. It might have been worthwhile to have paid some attention to regional formations of the post-Gupta period, too.

While discussing the coming of Islam, the Delhi Sultanate, and the age of the "magnificent Mughals", the author notes: "The characterisation of Muslim rulers as destructive and despotic was popularised by the British in the nineteenth century onwards to justify their rule as just and benevolent." Apart from Akbar and his pluralism, Jahangir receives special attention for his patronage of painting, exemplified by a drawing of the dodo.

The 18th century saw the establishment of British rule. Territorial expansion and colonial consolidation were momentarily checked by the struggle of 1857-58, and the national movement gathered momentum at the beginning of the twentieth century. The two concluding chapters survey developments of the post-1947 period, stating, "If the billion-plus citizens of India are given the chance to achieve their full potential", India's "greatest moments are yet to come". ■

-Amar Farooqui